

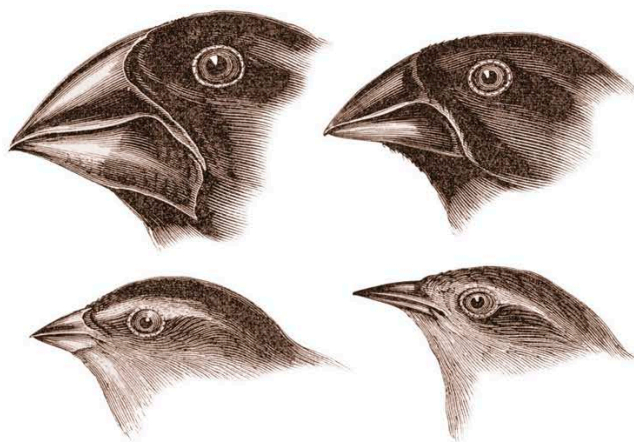
MARIE CURIE

Together with her husband Pierre, Marie Curie studied radioactivity (how atoms can break apart and release radiation) and discovered two new radioactive elements—polonium and radium. She also developed ways in which radioactivity could be used to treat cancers. Marie Curie won the Nobel Prize twice for her breakthrough work—the first in physics and the second in chemistry.

The progress of science

Scientific discoveries and developments transformed the world in the 19th century. As the study of science became an admired profession, and not just an eccentric hobby, the pace of scientific progress quickened. Discoveries led to new technologies and inventions, and scientists came up with theories that challenged people's beliefs. Russian chemist Dmitri Mendeleev devised the periodic table, a way of organizing chemical elements that led not only to the discovery of new elements but also helped scientists figure out how atoms—the building blocks of matter—are structured. Polish-French physicist Marie Curie was one of the first to reveal the secrets of radioactivity. An equally important step in the progress of science was English scientist Charles Darwin's theory that life on Earth had developed through a process of evolution—a discovery that changed the way humans saw the natural world.

1750–1900



▲ DARWIN'S THEORY OF EVOLUTION

During a visit to the Galápagos Islands off the South American coast, Charles Darwin noticed differences between the beaks of finches on the various islands. He wondered if this was because the finches had adapted in different ways to the food available in their habitats in order to survive. This led him to the idea that over time plants and animals gradually change and develop into new species—the theory of evolution.